

The Rule That Raises Your Rent Is Now Law

The child-benefit housing change, found, filed, and dated — verified against the Gazette

The Alberta Disability System Breakdown · St. Albert, Alberta · August 2026

What changed: a new rule now lets the government count money that never appears on your tax return, like the child benefits, as income when your rent in social housing is worked out. It was signed June 29, 2026 and published July 31, 2026. It becomes law on **January 1, 2027**. It was not announced, and it came bundled with two unrelated housekeeping rules.

What we found

For weeks we have been watching for the instrument that would let the Canada Child Benefit and the Alberta Child and Family Benefit be counted in the income used to set rent in social housing. It has now been found, verified in the government's own Gazette. It is Alberta Regulation 180/2026, the Social Housing Accommodation Amendment Regulation, made by Ministerial Order 2026-018.

It was made on June 29, filed July 9, and published July 31, 2026. It comes into force January 1, 2027, the same date the government has said it will start counting child benefits in the Rent Assistance Benefit.

The exact words

The new rule adds this power to the Social Housing Accommodation Regulation:

“The Minister may include any income or any other amount received by a member of a household that is not included in line 15000 of the member’s Notice of Assessment in the calculation of the total annual income of a household for the purposes of setting basic rent.”

Line 15000 is the total income line on your federal tax assessment. The child benefits are not reported there. So this new power reaches exactly the money that does not show up on your tax return, which is precisely what the child benefits are. That phrase has no other purpose.

Why this one is different, and harder to fight

Notice what the rule does not do. It does not name the Canada Child Benefit or the Alberta Child and Family Benefit anywhere. It simply gives the Minister the power to count non-tax-return income, by ministerial discretion. That means the decision to count a specific benefit does not have to be filed, published, or indexed anywhere. There is no second rule to watch for. Once this is in force, the counting can begin with nothing further made public.

The practical effect. Rent in social housing is set at 30 per cent of household income. As a rough guide, for every \$100 of child benefit that gets counted, about \$30 more a month goes to rent. That lands on families with children, including many disabled parents and parents of disabled children.

The timeline

- **January 1, 2027** — the new power comes into force. The announced date for counting child benefits in the Rent Assistance Benefit.
- **January 1, 2028** — the announced date for counting child benefits across all community housing.

Two other changes that came in the same rule

This regulation also did two things worth knowing, on the same January 1, 2027 date. It narrowed who is eligible for community housing: government-sponsored refugees and people with a pending refugee or immigration claim are no longer named as an eligible group. And it set a minimum rent floor, so basic rent cannot go below a prescribed minimum, which limits some of the reductions seniors and others could previously receive.

What this means for the fight

This is now law, so the goal is no longer to stop the rule. It is to watch how the discretion gets used, and to be ready, because the earliest sign that child benefits are being counted will not be a new law. It will be a rent notice, a tenant letter, or a line in a housing policy manual. If you are in social housing or on the Rent Assistance Benefit and your rent calculation changes, that is the moment, send it to us.

Nothing changes on your rent today. Put this in next year's plan rather than meeting it as a surprise at your annual review.

Sources: Alberta Regulation 180/2026, Social Housing Accommodation Amendment Regulation (Ministerial Order 2026-018), amending AR 244/1994; The Alberta Gazette, Part II, Vol. 122, No. 14, July 31, 2026; 2026 Gazette Part II Cumulative Index, August 17, 2026. Verified against the King's Printer, August 31, 2026. Effect, not motive.

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